A tire-slashing spree against Waymo robotaxis

Over three days in June 2024 someone in San Francisco went through the city slashing the tires of Waymo robotaxis — seventeen counts, each captured by the cameras on the cars being cut.

By the Clerk · 24 June 2024 · 2 min read

CASE:	BAS-0005
SUBJECT:	A defendant charged by the San Francisco District Attorney
OBJECT:	Waymo robotaxis, autonomous vehicles
DATE:	24 June 2024
PLACE:	San Francisco, California
FILED:	6 October 2026
GRADE:	HARM · INDIVIDUAL
AGGRAVATING:	repetition

Facts

Between 24 and 26 June 2024, someone cut the tires of Waymo robotaxis at seventeen separate places in San Francisco. The San Francisco Standard lists them: five on the 24th, around Seventh and Brannan, Third and Stevenson, Van Ness and O'Farrell and the Embarcadero; nine on the 25th, between Sutter and Gough and Lincoln Way and 19th Avenue; three in the early hours of the 26th, including Leavenworth and Union and Octavia and Haight. Per TechCrunch the weapon was a knife.

Every incident was recorded by the cameras that Waymo's cars carry on their outsides. CBS reports that police found the same person and the same vehicle in every case, and located the vehicle, a past-due rental car, on 26 June. NBC and the Standard say some of the cars had riders in them; no rider was hurt. CBS adds a related allegation, that the defendant also slashed the tires of a three-car Waymo convoy and of the rental car.

On 11 July the San Francisco District Attorney's office announced seventeen counts of vandalism, each alleging damage of more than $400. The defendant pleaded not guilty at arraignment on 10 July and was held without bail as a public-safety risk. A preliminary hearing was set for 23 July. None of the sources gives a motive. This record has found no report of the case's outcome.

The defendant was named by all four outlets. This record does not repeat the name.

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Statements

District Attorney Brooke Jenkins, as quoted by CBS, NBC and the Standard: “The destruction of other people’s property will not go unaddressed in San Francisco.”

Waymo, per NBC: “We can confirm that charges have been brought against the individual who aggressively vandalized a number of Waymo vehicles, some with riders present.” A spokesperson, per TechCrunch: “Waymo is also taking steps to recover damages and mitigate future events.”

The defense attorney, Adam Birka-White, per NBC and the Standard: “[The defendant] is someone in need of help and not jail.” NBC adds that the defense intends to fight the charges.

For the record

The District Attorney’s statement files the cars under other people’s property. Each of the seventeen counts rests on footage the cars took of the cutting themselves, from the cameras the cars carry.

Mitigating circumstances

Per the defense, the defendant needs help more than jail. NBC reports that the defendant said they were homeless in San Francisco. The charges are allegations; the sources report a plea of not guilty and no conviction. No one was hurt, and each count alleges damage of more than $400, which the sources do not put higher.



SOURCES

1. David Ingram, Man accused of slashing tires of 17 Waymo robotaxis was allegedly caught on camera (archived), NBC News, 11 July 2024
2. Tim Fang, Man charged with vandalizing 17 Waymo robotaxis in San Francisco (archived), CBS News San Francisco, 11 July 2024
3. Maxwell Zeff, Waymo cameras capture footage of man charged in alleged robotaxi tire slashings (archived), TechCrunch, 12 July 2024
4. Tomo Chien, Waymo tire slash suspect San Francisco, The San Francisco Standard, 11 July 2024

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